the biggest circular table I have seen—discussing the global economic situation and exchanging their own country perspectives.

The code of conduct governing the BIS meetings is that what is discussed within the room stays within the room. No record or minutes are kept and no attribution is to be made to anyone in any discussion beyond the meeting room. This format allows for a frank expression of country situations and policy dilemmas, and a freewheeling exchange of perspectives and ideas. The GEM was an excellent forum to get a clear and candid briefing on the developments in the advanced economies from their respective governors. This heads-up was particularly useful during the global financial crisis as it helped those of us from emerging markets to be better prepared to respond to those developments.

I feel quite nostalgic about this bimonthly trip to Basel on many counts; they were also memorable for the efficiency with which the BIS ran the logistics of the meeting—right from the time of receiving each governor at the airport on arrival to dropping us back there at the end of the meetings, they demonstrated the best practice for understated deference and unfailing courtesy.

G20 Meetings

Let me now turn to the G20 meetings of finance ministers and central bank governors which I found useful but also taxing.

The G20 is an informal club with nineteen member countries and the European Union that together represent 90 per cent of global GDP, 80 per cent of global trade and two-thirds of the global population. Contrary to popular perception, the G20 is not a new international grouping triggered by the global financial crisis. It was, in fact, triggered by an earlier crisis, the Asian crisis of 1997.

The G20 has been meeting regularly since 1997, twice a year, at the level of finance ministers and central bank governors. One important change brought on by the crisis was to elevate the level of the meeting with the introduction of an annual meeting of leaders—the Leaders' Forum—which